

“I am not a YouTuber who can make whatever video I want. I have to keep appeasing algorithms”: Bureaucracy of Creator Moderation on YouTube

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ABSTRACT

Recent HCI studies have recognized an analogy between bureaucracy and algorithmic systems; given platformization of content creators, video sharing platforms like YouTube and TikTok practice creator moderation, i.e., an assemblage of algorithms that manage not only creators’ content but also their income, visibility, identities, and more. However, it has not been fully understood as to how bureaucracy manifests in creator moderation. In this poster, we present an interview study with 28 YouTubers (i.e., video content creators) to analyze the bureaucracy of creator moderation from their moderation experiences. We found participants wrestled with bureaucracy as multiple obstructions in re-examining moderation decisions, coercion to appease different algorithms in creator moderation, and the platform’s indifference to participants’ labor. We discuss and contribute a conceptual understanding of how algorithmic and organizational bureaucracy intertwine in creator moderation, laying a solid ground for our future study.

CCS CONCEPTS

• Human-centered computing; • Collaborative and social computing; • Empirical studies in collaborative and social computing;

KEYWORDS

creator moderation, content moderation, algorithmic moderation, YouTuber

ACM Reference Format:

Renkai Ma and Yubo Kou. 2022. “I am not a YouTuber who can make whatever video I want. I have to keep appeasing algorithms”: Bureaucracy of Creator Moderation on YouTube. In *Companion Computer Supported Cooperative Work and Social Computing (CSCW’22 Companion)*, November 08–22, 2022, Virtual Event, Taiwan. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 6 pages. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3500868.3559445>

1 INTRODUCTION

Recent HCI studies have shown bureaucratic traits of algorithmic systems. Rooted in organization science, the notion of bureaucracy refers to rule-governed procedures that are inflexible to adapt

decision-making processes to novel cases [9]. HCI researchers have demonstrated how bureaucracy is embedded in algorithms that support or automate decision-making. For example, on Amazon Mechanical Turk, quality assessment algorithms would not assign new tasks to workers if their past work was not completed as gold-standard solutions in the algorithms’ training dataset [2, 17].

This analogy between algorithmic systems and bureaucracy also exists in creator moderation. Beyond the purpose of content moderation that regulates the appropriateness of creative content, creator moderation consists of multiple governance mechanisms managing content creators’ visibility [3, 4, 8], identity [4], revenue [5, 7], labor [7], and more. Given platformization and monetization of creative labor [10, 19, 27], video sharing platforms like YouTube and TikTok tend to practice creator moderation through an assemblage of various algorithms (e.g., monetization, content moderation, recommendation algorithms, and more) [23]. So, creators may correspondingly experience moderation such as demonetization [7, 22] or shadowban [3, 29]. However, as interests in the CSCW community grow in understanding creators’ moderation experiences (e.g., [22, 23]), relatively little attention has been paid to unpacking or elaborating on bureaucratic traits of creator moderation, so we ask: **How do content creators navigate bureaucracy in creator moderation?** In this poster, we call the algorithms conducting creator moderation as moderation algorithms holistically when not specifying certain algorithms such as recommendation algorithms.

To answer the research question, we interviewed 28 YouTubers who had experienced creator moderation. Through an inductive qualitative analysis [21, 31], we identified three primary ways that YouTubers wrestled with bureaucracy: (1) multiple obstructions prevented our participants from appealing moderation decisions; (2) participants felt they were coerced to appease different types of algorithms; (3) participants thought their labor was undervalued by the platform.

We discuss how bureaucracy is embedded in creator moderation procedures on YouTube, which shares similar traits with not only algorithmic bureaucracy but also organizational bureaucracy of online community governance. Organizational bureaucracy refers to privileged moderation decision-making for some users than others. One such example appears on Wikipedia regarding content exclusion for editors’ contributions. It entails role-based goals of maintaining an encyclopedia by assigning hierarchical roles to users such as site owners, sighter (i.e., old users), voluntary users, or unregistered ones [6, 25], where old members are exempt from review to contribute content [20]. We show that our participants first experienced algorithmic bureaucracy from moderation decisions and then organizational bureaucracy when appealing the decisions. This exploratory study aims to contribute to the HCI and CSCW

*This work is partially supported by NSF grant No. 2006854

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CSCW’22 Companion, November 08–22, 2022, Virtual Event, Taiwan

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ACM ISBN 978-1-4503-9190-0/22/11.

<https://doi.org/10.1145/3500868.3559445>

Table 1: Participant profiles. Subscription # (fanbase) was collected on the date of the interviews. Status was identified by YouTubers themselves by the time spent on creating videos. Career refers to how long YouTubers consistently make videos for their primary channel. Category refers to content category, which is defined by YouTube. “N/A” means the information that our participants chose not to disclose.

#	Sub #	Age	Status	Nationality	Race	Gender	Career	Category
P1	~ 25.8k	18	part-time	US	White	Male	5 months	Games
P2	~ 21.3k	23	full-time	US	White	Male	5 years	Games
P3	~ 6.6k	40	part-time	England	White	Male	3 years	Travel
P4	~ 52k	28	part-time	US	Black	Female	6 years	People
P5	~ 4.33k	19	part-time	England	White	Male	5 years	Technology
P6	~ 268k	29	full-time	US	White	Male	9 years	Animation
P7	~ 84.7K	29	full-time	US	White	Male	3 years	Games
P8	~ 177k	32	part-time	US	White	Male	3.5 years	History
P9	~ 365k	28	full-time	Germany	White	Male	2 years	Entertainment
P10	~ 23.1k	38	part-time	Mexico	Hispanic	Female	2.5 years	Education
P11	~ 292k	29	part-time	Brazil	White	Female	12 years	Entertainment
P12	~ 2.02k	21	part-time	England	White	Male	2.5 years	Education
P13	~ 124k	19	full-time	US	Hispanic	Male	4 years	Entertainment
P14	~ 88.6k	28	part-time	Colombia	Hispanic	Male	2 years	Education
P15	~ 12.6k	29	part-time	Mexico	Hispanic	Male	6 years	Education
P16	~ 35.5k	29	part-time	Mexico	Hispanic	Female	4 years	Technology
P17	~ 5.7k	21	part-time	US	N/A	Male	8 years	Entertainment
P18	~ 26.8k	29	part-time	Mexico	Hispanic	Female	3 years	Education
P19	~ 53.9k	32	part-time	Mexico	Hispanic	Female	3 years	Technology
P20	~ 8.8k	18	part-time	US	White	Male	2 years	Games
P21	~ 497k	25	full-time	US	N/A	Male	2 years	Entertainment
P22	~ 230k	22	part-time	US	White	Male	7 years	Animation
P23	~ 31.3k	48	part-time	Colombia	Latino	Male	5 years	Education
P24	~ 63.2k	31	part-time	US	White	Male	5 years	History
P25	~ 52k	48	part-time	US	White	Male	3 years	Film
P26	~ 5.51k	27	part-time	US	Asian	Female	1 year	Entertainment
P27	~ 60.6k	55	full-time	US	White	Male	2 years	Technology
P28	~ 21.4k	23	full-time	Demark	Mixed	Male	6 months	Entertainment

research with a conceptual understanding of how algorithmic and organizational bureaucracy intertwine in creator moderation.

2 METHODS: DATA COLLECTION AND ANALYSIS

After the approval from our institution’s Institutional Review Board (IRB) board, we interviewed 28 YouTubers (See Table 1) to answer our research question. We used purposeful sampling [31] with recruitment criteria that participants must be over 18 years old and have experienced creator moderation (e.g., “limited ads,” [35] copyright claims [5, 18], or other types). We shared the recruitment information on Twitter, Facebook, and Reddit. From January to October 2021, we interviewed 28 YouTubers. Every participant was compensated with a \$ 20 gift card, with three proactively refused reimbursement.

Through Zoom, all interviews were conducted through a semi-structured interview protocol involving two sections. After we received verbal consent from each participant, we conducted (1) warm-up questions, such as demographics and YouTube usage questions (e.g., frequency of publishing videos), and then (2) moderation

experiences questions such as what moderation and explanations they received, how they were impacted, and probes, i.e., follow-up questions.

We used an inductive thematic analysis on our interview dataset [21]. This procedure was expanded in three steps. First, two coders separately ran ‘open coding’: screening the data and assigned codes to excerpts that could answer our research question. Then, the coders conducted ‘axial coding’ by combining open coding codes into themes. Finally, the data analysis ended by running ‘selective coding’ where relevant themes were grouped into overarching themes.

3 FINDINGS

We found three aspects of bureaucracy in creator moderation: (1) multiple obstacles to appeal moderation decisions, (2) coercion to appease different algorithms, and (3) the platform’s indifference to participants’ individual labor.

3.1 Obstruction in Layers

Obstruction in layers means multiple obstacles that our participants encountered to appeal moderation decisions. After the issuance of such decisions, YouTubers could request human reviewers' re-examination on them (e.g., contacting creator support [36], requesting a review [37]). This appeared to be a straightforward procedure, but our participants experienced it as indirect and layered. They observed a hierarchy in terms of who could actually reach human reviewers. Then, they were instructed to take lengthy and confusing steps to achieve their goals.

3.1.1 Hierarchical Communication. Hierarchical communication means that the communication channels between YouTubers and the creator moderation system have varying qualities and efficiencies. For instance, P24 said:

In terms of tangible support for it (video deletion), there wasn't really much. It was more about the leadership of the Slack community (WeCreateEdu) [who] basically reached out to their contacts on YouTube, which [was] fairly high up in the content moderation area, and then it was just a matter of a waiting game. [P24]

WeCreateEdu is a group of YouTubers who create educational content on YouTube, and they had built an online community on Slack, a business communication platform. In the above case, P24 acknowledged a hierarchical feature of moderation where YouTube maintained closed contacts with organizers of a specific YouTube community. Because existing appeal procedures did not help re-examine P24's video deletion punishment, he turned to leverage the community's contacts for better solutions. However, P24 himself did not have such access.

Some participants had successfully contacted human reviewers through third-party platforms (e.g., Twitter), while they witnessed more disproportionate conversations compared with other YouTubers. For instance, P2 said:

(...) or a big YouTuber like [YouTuber A:] he's having a bunch of issues on his channel, and it has over 10 million subscribers. So, he went on back and forth, and you can probably look that (chatting history) up with the team YouTube. But if you follow team YouTube on Twitter, you can see all kinds of conversations that people [are] yelling at them because they don't do anything. They're really there for the elite people. [P2]

@TeamYouTube is a YouTube team's official Twitter account offering help to YouTubers. P2 witnessed it offered hierarchical length of conversations between a YouTuber with a larger fanbase (i.e., YouTuber A) and small YouTubers. He thus assumed fanbase was critical for YouTube to offer better responses to requests for solving moderation issues.

3.1.2 Inefficient Process. Inefficient process describes that participants experienced appeal as complex and lengthy, resulting in undue delays. After moderation algorithms issued decisions, some participants chose to appeal through YouTube's platform support (e.g., creator support [36]). However, this did not mean participants

could effectively solve moderation issues as they wished. For example, P7, a YouTuber who experienced channel demonetization, said:

They (YouTube) want you to go through the forms and the formulas. They had sent me one link, and it said if you believe it was an error, you can reapply to the YouTube partnership program in 30 days as long as you're not breaking any rules. But what rules am I breaking in videos? There's no information; it's like a wall. [P7]

Channel demonetization means a YouTuber's whole channel becomes illegible to earn ad income from videos. In the above case, P7 needed to wait a certain period of time to appeal such moderation. However, without knowing what content rules he violated, his appeal might fail to be initiated once he is deemed to violate content rules again. Thus, extending prior work's findings that users encountered the opacity of appeal on Reddit [16] or Instagram [11], we found that on YouTube, the opacity of moderation decision-making further became an obstacle of effectively initiating appeals.

We also found that time was an important factor in doing so. P3 shared his experiences of appealing 'limited ads': *You can appeal demonetization, and then it's amazing [they] will take 27 or 28 days, and then they reject you. Or you're about to get to the 28th day, and you win because they haven't found [anything] [problematic].* [P3]

"Limited ads" means a video is not suitable for most advertisers, so its ad income will be decreased or removed. YouTube's content rules state that human review on 'limited ads' takes up to 7 days [37]. However, P3 waited more than that for moderation systems to process his appeals. His negative tone further expressed the desire for moderation system's better efficiency since time matters for monetization. As P19, who experienced "limited ads," elaborated, *"We lost money because I need to wait for a response back from YouTube."*

3.2 Appeasing Algorithms under Coercion

Appeasing algorithms under coercion refers to situations where participants felt coerced into appeasing different types of algorithms. Not only did participants experience content moderation that prior work has primarily investigated (e.g., [13–15, 33]), but they also felt forced to negotiate for their content existence, income, visibility, and more. Some participants unconditionally followed whatever decisions algorithms issued, such as what P7 said: *It (self-certification) will say congratulations, you're rating your videos accurately, and in future uploads, we will automatically monetize you depending on your own answers* [P7]. Self-certification is an algorithmic function for a YouTuber to self-report whether a new video complies with different sections in advertiser-friendly content guidelines before publishing it. P7's case showed he actively contributed his uncompensated labor for the platform to train self-certification algorithms/functions better. For another example, after a community guideline strike (i.e., a content warning), P13 described how he appealed monetization and recommendation algorithms:

I kind of do feel like I was targeted, especially after the false strike. (...) It hurt my motivation very much because it takes a while for my videos to get pushed

(by recommendation algorithms), and I have to make longer videos that are more watch time intensive because that's what the algorithms like. [P13]

After the strike, P13 observed YouTube's recommendation algorithms did not actively promote his videos, so his ad income decreased sharply. He assumed that longer videos could be more recommendable to the algorithms because they are more profitable: more mid-roll ads can be placed on a video that is longer than eight minutes [38]. Thus, P13 created longer videos to appease recommendation and monetization algorithms for more ad income.

However, some participants chose not to appease YouTube, and they experienced negative consequences happening to their channel performance. For instance, P8, a YouTuber who created history content experienced 'limited ads,' said:

They have rendered certain topics off limits. (...) I tend to be a little brazen, but that hurts my channel to grow and to be seen. (...) YouTube is fostering a climate in which talking about the Holocaust is impossible. That's a problem. (...) These things (videos) were mostly derived from a lecture that I actually gave to students, and yet I am heavily discouraged from doing it on YouTube. [P8]

Advertiser-friendly content guidelines allow violent content "in a news, educational, artistic, or documentary context" [39]. P8 felt the moderation he received unreasonable and believed that there were latent boundaries of discussing specific topics beyond existing content rules. This case showed how algorithmic systems of creator moderation on YouTube failed to adapt decision-making processes to novel cases. P8's insistence on creating Holocaust history content that he considered completely acceptable on YouTube showed that he refused to appease YouTube. However, such decision caused negative impacts on his channel's monetization, visibility, and growth.

3.3 Indifference to Individual Labor

Indifference to individual labor refers to our participants' complaints that YouTube showed little care to the value of their individual labor. Extending prior work that discusses labor structures on YouTube [7, 27], we further showed how YouTubers subjectively sense YouTube's indifferent attitudes toward their labor. For example, P2 said:

It (suspension) actually deleted all my money or monetization for April, which was over 700,000 views for my other videos; it was like a couple of hundred dollars. (...) Because my channel got deleted on May 1, and I hadn't processed it by the 12th, I never saw that money. And they never told me what happened to that money. [P2]

YouTube processes monetization (e.g., ad income) from the 7th to 12th of each month for their profits generated in the last month. P2 did not receive the ad income generated from videos with all normal monetization statuses due to account suspension. This inequality in profit distribution indicated platform indifference to P2's labor.

Furthermore, participants complained that demonetization revealed YouTube's lack of intent to help them monetize videos in

common ways. For example, P25, a YouTuber who create videos of horror movie compilation, said:

It says limited ads, but a video like mine is tamer than an episode of the walking dead. The Walking Dead is on AMC, that's a basic cable network; they find many people to advertise on that show. So, I don't believe that YouTube can't find advertisers on horror film content or whatever [for me]. I think they just don't try. [P25]

P25's ad income was decreased because the moderation system deemed that his videos depicted violence and were not suitable for advertisers. P25 believed that his content could be friendly for certain categories of ads, so he complained about YouTube's limited endeavors to help find matched advertisers for him. Although YouTube and AMC might have different standards in content rules, P25's case showed his impression of YouTube's limited care for him to re-monetize.

4 DISCUSSION & FUTURE WORK

Extending the prior work on experiences of content moderation (e.g., [14, 22, 24, 30, 33]), we showed how YouTubers experienced the bureaucracy of creator moderation. That is, bureaucracy is embedded in moderation procedures, sharing similar traits with both algorithmic bureaucracy and organizational bureaucracy of online community governance.

Similar to how prior work discusses algorithmic bureaucracy [2, 26], this study found that moderation algorithms failed to contextualize our participants' video content for moderation decision-making. YouTube largely automates moderation decision-making through algorithms (e.g., machine learning) [1, 12, 28]. It, however, remains questionable how moderation algorithms can ensure content rules in a qualitative manner (e.g., judgment, discourse) to be perfectly translated to identify user content as unacceptable, especially given our participants' complaints on latent content rules.

Algorithmic bureaucracy on YouTube keeps expanding its scope and complexity, sometimes involving more uncompensated labor from YouTubers. An example is YouTube's "self-certification" function to improve algorithmic accuracy. Consequently, YouTubers like P7 willingly provided much uncompensated, voluntary work so that moderation algorithms, including monetization, recommendation, and more, could be trained better. This means, instead of making algorithms more flexible for YouTubers, the platform makes YouTubers adapt to the inflexible algorithms.

Organizational bureaucracy [20, 25] in creator moderation on YouTube lies partly in its invisible hierarchy. Prior work has discussed the hierarchical orders of users in moderation decision-making for articles on Wikipedia [25]. Similarly, our findings showed the hierarchy of appeal processes. Some YouTubers can access certain human reviewers for privileged interpretational interactions and solutions to moderation issues. While hierarchical moderation decision-making on Wikipedia is somehow visible to all community members, the hierarchy in creator moderation is largely invisible. Thus, YouTubers have a longer learning curve to figure out these complexities and intricacies.

Content policies serve to ratify such organizational bureaucracy. Researchers criticize existing content rules rarely consider the context of user content [32, 34], easily leading to algorithmic bureaucracy. We further showed that content rule acted as an obstacle: it provided excuses, such as the 30-day rule, to justify the perceived low efficiency of processing appeals, and prevented YouTubers from returning to earn ad income from time-sensitive content for a prolonged period.

Thus, the bureaucracy of creator moderation is both algorithmic and organizational: YouTubers would first experience algorithmic bureaucracy upon receiving moderation decisions and then organizational bureaucracy when initiating appeals. Organizational bureaucracy works to exacerbate the repercussions of algorithmic bureaucracy. Lengthy undue procedures ahead, our participants could only wait for algorithmic decisions to be re-examined by human reviewers. With limited power in such unbalanced labor relation, participants like P13 acquired a mindset of "appeasing algorithms" or sacrificed personal preferences and interests to meet demands that they believed to be unreasonable.

This poster's late-breaking findings, how algorithmic bureaucracy and organizational bureaucracy intersect in creator moderation, will inform our future studies. Building on these findings, we plan to study the complex relationships between bureaucratic moderation systems and user communities, how user agency plays a role in such relationships, and how platform policies could be designed to prevent bureaucracy and support users in constructive ways.

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